

Primary Prevention in British Columbia: Preliminary Findings on Quantitative Cancer Risk Indicators

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Introduction: Modifiable lifestyle factors, environmental exposures and infections contribute to the development of many cancer types. Four in ten cancer cases in Canada can be prevented through healthy living behaviours and supportive policies. Priority risk factors include smoking, alcohol, exercise, diet, ultraviolet radiation, environmental and occupational exposures, and infections. As exemplified by Cancer Care Ontario, BC Cancer intends to develop a report of quantitative indicators on policies and programs addressing cancer risk factors and exposures in British Columbia.

Objectives: Conduct background research on potential quantitative cancer risk indicators, identification and evaluation of data sources, linking indicators to public health goals for cancer prevention and proposing a reporting framework for B.C.

Methods: An environmental scan and literature review were conducted addressing all eight risk factors. Search strategies were generated using the ECLIPSE framework. Keywords were combined using Boolean operators in Google Scholar and PubMed. The environmental scan assessed internal (n = 62) and external (n = 64) gray literature to BC Cancer. The literature review incorporated title/abstract screening (n = 131) and full-text screening (n = 67) of peer-reviewed articles. Relevant data was extracted, and key themes collated into a summary report for further analysis.

Results: Risk factor-specific results showcase indicators identified within prevalence data, harm reduction guidelines and policies, behavioural interventions and public health programming at individual, community and societal levels within B.C.

Recommendations: Future directions include operationalization of the built environment in community-based programs for cancer prevention, and indicator stratification to highlight significant differences due to social determinants of health.

Conclusion: As provision of health care is decentralized in Canada, this work emphasizes the importance of prioritizing primary cancer prevention strategies specific to B.C.